Students' Congress on Innovation, Informatics, and Computing (SCII-Com '26)

Comparative Analysis of Deep Reinforcement Learning Algorithms for Anomaly Detection in IoT-Based Cyberattacks

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Abstract: *The rapid proliferation of Internet of Things (IoT) devices has expanded cyberattack surfaces, particularly in resource-constrained networks vulnerable to short-burst attacks where labeled data is scarce. This paper presents a systematic, semi-supervised comparison of four Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) algorithms for IoT anomaly detection: off-policy Deep Q-Network (DQN), Quantile Regression DQN (QR-DQN), on-policy Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO), and Recurrent PPO with LSTM. A pretrained Convolutional Autoencoder (ConvAE) generates reconstruction errors as intrinsic rewards combined with sparse labeled signals over sliding-window time-series (length 32, 47 features) on Edge-IIoTset. Agents operate on 129-dimensional states of latent embeddings and normalized reconstruction errors. Recurrent PPO achieves the best results (F1: 0.9342, AUC-ROC: 0.9573) through LSTM temporal modeling. Ablation studies confirm the optimal ConvAE threshold (IQR-based, T = 0.0902 MSE) and replay buffer size. The reproducible framework clarifies off-policy versus on-policy trade-offs for practical IoT security deployments.*

Keywords: Deep Reinforcement Learning; IoT anomaly detection; semi-supervised learning; Convolutional Autoencoder; Edge-IIoTset

I. INTRODUCTION

The Internet of Things (IoT) has become deeply embedded in critical sectors including smart homes, industrial automation, healthcare, and smart infrastructure. By 2025, the number of connected IoT devices exceeded 15 billion globally and continues to grow rapidly [1]. This proliferation substantially enlarges the cyberattack surface of modern networks. Many IoT devices are severely resource-constrained in terms of CPU, memory, and power, often shipping with weak or non-existent built-in security, and communicating via heterogeneous protocols such as MQTT, CoAP, Modbus/TCP, and HTTP. These characteristics make them attractive targets for adversaries seeking to exploit vulnerable nodes through denial-of-service (DoS/DDoS) floods, man-in-the-middle (MitM) manipulation, botnet-based compromise, port scanning, and injection attacks [2].

Anomaly detection has emerged as the preferred defense paradigm in IoT environments because it identifies deviations from normal behavior without requiring prior knowledge of attack signatures, enabling detection of zero-day threats that evade signature-based systems [3]. However, conventional supervised deep learning models require large, fully labeled datasets that are expensive and impractical to acquire in operational IoT networks. Semi-supervised methods based on autoencoders and Isolation Forest reduce the labeling burden but generally lack the adaptive, sequential decision-making capabilities necessary to track evolving attack behaviors over time.

Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) addresses this limitation by learning detection policies through reward-based interaction with a streaming environment. The DPLAN framework [4] demonstrated that a DQN agent guided by Isolation Forest anomaly priors could generalize from a small labeled set to unseen attacks. Two major DRL families exist: off-policy algorithms (DQN, QR-DQN), which learn value functions via experience replay; and on-policy algorithms (PPO, Recurrent PPO with LSTM), which optimize policies directly from current experience. Off-policy methods are generally more sample-efficient due to replay buffer reuse, while on-policy methods offer more stable policy updates in non-stationary environments. Each family has distinct trade-offs in sample efficiency, stability, and temporal modeling capacity, and no prior work has conducted a controlled comparison of both families under identical semi-supervised conditions on IoT time-series data.

This paper fills the gap with three contributions: (1) a semi-supervised DRL framework using a ConvAE for intrinsic reward generation over sliding-window IoT traffic; (2) a systematic four-algorithm comparison (DQN, QR-DQN, PPO, Recurrent PPO) under identical hyperparameters and dataset partitioning; and (3) comprehensive ablation studies on ConvAE confidence thresholds and replay buffer size on the Edge-IIoTset benchmark [5].

II. RELATED WORK

A. Classical and Deep Learning Approaches

Early IoT anomaly detection relied on classical methods including SVM, k-NN, Isolation Forest, and Gaussian Mixture Models [6]. Deep learning methods such as CNNs, LSTMs, GRUs, and Transformers subsequently enabled end-to-end feature learning on benchmarks including BoT-IoT, UNSW-NB15, and Edge-IIoTset [7]. Autoencoder-based detection has proven particularly effective under label scarcity: a model trained on benign traffic learns a compact normal-behavior manifold, and reconstruction errors on unseen sequences serve as anomaly scores. Meidan et al. [8] demonstrated this on

nine IoT devices, identifying Mirai and BASHLITE botnet infections. Ferrag et al. [5] validated convolutional autoencoder variants on Edge-IIoTset, reporting F1-scores exceeding 0.98 in multi-class detection.

B. Deep Reinforcement Learning for Intrusion Detection

DRL has been applied to security tasks including dynamic firewall rule selection, adaptive honeypot deployment, and anomaly-based traffic classification [9]. DQN [10] approximates action-value functions with deep networks stabilized by experience replay and target network updates; its off-policy nature allows efficient reuse of past transitions, which is particularly valuable when labeled anomaly events are rare. PPO [11] optimizes a stochastic policy with a clipped surrogate objective that prevents destructive large policy updates, providing stability in non-stationary environments. QR-DQN [12] models the full return distribution through quantile regression over N quantiles, improving robustness under reward noise by capturing the uncertainty inherent in semi-supervised reward signals. Recurrent DRL variants integrate LSTM layers to maintain hidden states h_t across timesteps, enabling modeling of temporal attack patterns spanning multiple consecutive windows [13]. Prior work by Tang et al. [21] demonstrated that LSTM-augmented policy networks outperform memoryless counterparts by 8–12% on sequential network intrusion benchmarks, motivating our inclusion of Recurrent PPO as a key baseline.

C. Semi-Supervised DRL and the DPLAN Framework

The most directly related prior work is DPLAN [4], which casts anomaly detection as a semi-supervised DRL problem: a DQN agent receives Isolation Forest outlier scores as intrinsic rewards alongside sparse extrinsic rewards from a small labeled anomaly set, achieving AUC-ROC of 0.8712. Our work extends DPLAN by: (1) replacing Isolation Forest with a ConvAE as the intrinsic reward source; (2) extending the comparison to four DRL algorithms; and (3) evaluating on multivariate sliding-window IoT time-series from Edge-IIoTset. Fig. 1 shows the original DPLAN architecture; Fig. 2 shows our proposed modification.

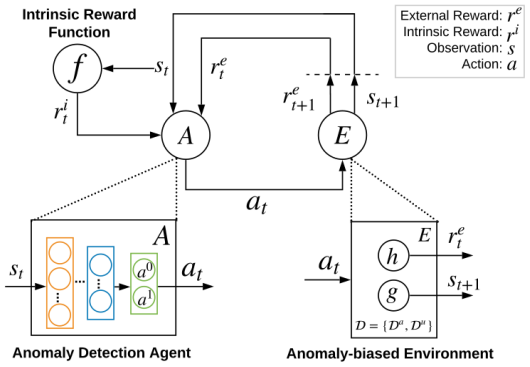


Fig. 1. Original DPLAN framework (Pang et al., 2020).

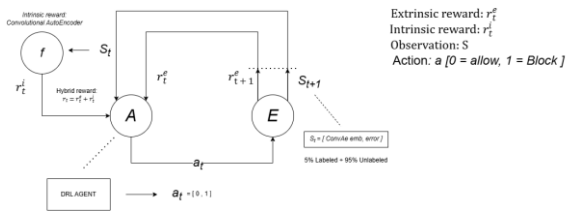


Fig. 2. Proposed DRL framework modified from DPLAN, using ConvAE as intrinsic reward source.

III. METHODOLOGY

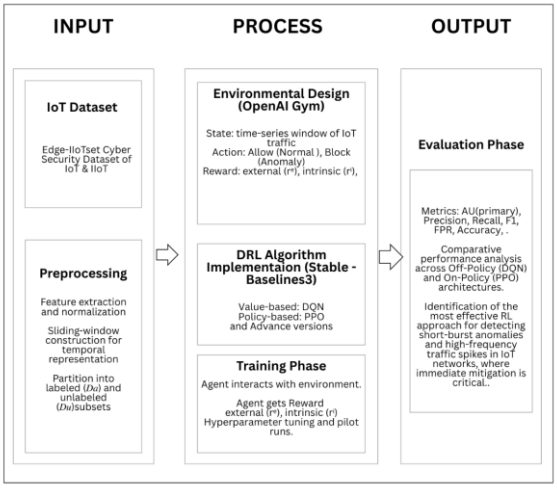


Fig. 3. Research pipeline of the proposed semi-supervised DRL framework.

A. Dataset: Edge-IIoTset

Edge-IIoTset [5] is a comprehensive IoT/IIoT cybersecurity dataset generated from a purpose-built testbed integrating Raspberry Pi 4, ESP32, Arduino Uno, smart TVs, and smartphones communicating over MQTT, CoAP, HTTP, and Modbus/TCP. It contains 2,219,201 labeled records across 14 distinct attack scenarios grouped into five categories: DDoS/DoS, Information Gathering, MitM, Injection, and Malware. Normal traffic constitutes 72.80% of all records. Table V shows the full class distribution. DDoS attacks dominate anomalous traffic at 84.85% combined, while rare attacks such as MITM (0.43%) and SQL Injection (0.34%) present the greatest semi-supervised detection challenge.

Table V. Edge-IIoTset class distribution (anomaly % relative to anomalous windows only).

Traffic Type	Category	Records	% (Anomaly)
Normal	—	1,599,283	72.80%
DDoS_UDP	DDoS/DoS	270,416	43.24%
DDoS_ICMP	DDoS/DoS	260,379	41.61%
Uploading	Malware	84,726	13.54%
Port Scan	Info. Gath.	9,218	1.47%
Ransomware	Malware	7,389	1.18%
Fingerprint.	Info. Gath.	4,511	0.72%
XSS	Injection	3,282	0.52%
MITM	MitM	2,692	0.43%
SQL Injection	Injection	2,103	0.34%
Backdoor	Malware	1,789	0.29%
Other	Multiple	1,041	0.17%

B. Preprocessing and Temporal Sequencing

Thirteen irrelevant identifier and payload columns are removed, leaving 47 features per packet after LabelEncoder categorical encoding and z-score normalization using training-set statistics. Records are sorted by frame.time to reconstruct chronological packet order. A sliding window of length w = 32 with stride s = 4

transforms the sequence into multivariate windows of shape (N×32×47), providing 87.50% overlap to ensure coverage of ephemeral short-burst attacks. A window is labeled anomalous if at least 30% of its constituent packets carry anomalous labels [15]. An 80/20 chronological train/test split is applied; 5% of anomalous training windows are randomly selected as labeled (sparse supervision), and the remaining 95% form the unlabeled set.

C. Convolutional Autoencoder

A 1D convolutional encoder-decoder is pretrained on normal traffic windows. The encoder applies Conv1D(47→32, k = 3) + AdaptiveMaxPool(16), Conv1D(32→64, k = 3) + AdaptiveMaxPool(8), followed by a linear projection to a 128-dimensional latent vector z. The decoder reverses this via linear expansion and two upsample + Conv1D stages. MSE loss is minimized using Adam with $\alpha = 1\times10^{-3}$ for up to 100 epochs with early stopping (patience = 5). Training converges at 30–50 epochs; anomalous windows produce reconstruction errors 2–5× higher than normal windows, confirming strong anomaly separability.

An IQR-based confidence threshold is derived from normal validation window errors ($Q_1 = 0.0164$, $Q_3 = 0.0459$, IQR = 0.0295):

$$T = Q_3 + 1.5 \times IQR = 0.0459 + 0.0443 = 0.0902\ MSE$$

The normalized reconstruction error for each window is:

$$e_{norm} = (e - \mu) / \sigma$$

where μ and σ are derived from the normal validation set. This threshold yields an estimated FPR of 5.39% on normal traffic alone.

C.1 ConvAE Training Results

Fig. 4 shows the train and validation MSE curves during ConvAE pretraining on normal sequences. Both curves exhibit a rapid drop from an initial MSE of approximately 0.43 (train) and 0.34 (validation) at epoch 1, followed by gradual convergence to the range 0.07–0.10 MSE after 30–40 epochs. The near-equality of the two curves throughout training confirms the absence of overfitting and demonstrates good generalization to unseen normal traffic sequences. Early stopping was triggered at approximately epoch 45–50 in most runs.

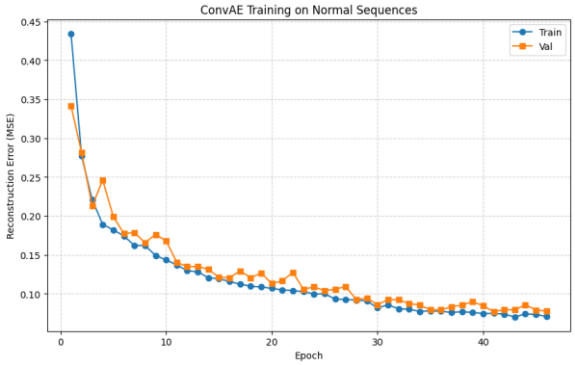


Fig. 4. Train and validation MSE during ConvAE pretraining on normal sequences.

To validate the anomaly separability of the learned representations, reconstruction errors were computed on a held-out sample of labeled anomalous windows after training. Anomalous windows consistently produced MSE values 2–5× higher than the normal window mean, confirming that the ConvAE successfully learned the normal-traffic manifold and that reconstruction error is a reliable unsupervised anomaly signal for the RL reward function.

Table VI summarizes the IQR-based threshold computation derived from normal validation window reconstruction errors. The Upper Fence (k = 1.5, T = 0.0902 MSE) was selected as the primary operating threshold, balancing detection sensitivity (FPR = 5.39%) with robustness to moderate reconstruction error variance. The conservative threshold (k = 3.0, T = 0.1345 MSE) achieves a lower FPR of 2.34% but misses weaker anomaly signals in the 0.0902–0.1345 range, as confirmed by the ablation results in Section IV-E.

Table VI. IQR-based confidence threshold computation on normal validation window errors.

Parameter	Value (MSE)
Q_1 (25th percentile, raw MSE)	0.0164
Q_3 (75th percentile, raw MSE)	0.0459
IQR = $Q_3 - Q_1$	0.0295
Upper Fence (k = 1.5)	0.0902
Conservative (k = 3.0)	0.1345

A custom OpenAI Gym environment processes training windows chronologically. At each timestep t, the agent receives a 129-dimensional state s_t formed by concatenating: (1) the frozen ConvAE latent embedding z_t = encoder(w_t) ∈ $\mathbb{R}^{128}$, capturing structural temporal patterns; and (2) the normalized reconstruction error, providing an explicit unsupervised anomaly signal. The binary action space is A = {0 = normal, 1 = anomaly}.

E. Hybrid Reward Function

The total reward $r_t = r_e + r_i$ combines sparse external supervision with dense intrinsic motivation, clipped to [−5.0, +5.0]:

$$r_t = r_e + r_i$$

The external reward r_e provides supervised signal on labeled windows only: r_e = +1.0 for a correct anomaly detection (TP); r_e = −0.5 for a missed labeled anomaly (FN); r_e = 0.0 on unlabeled windows.

The intrinsic reward r_i is entirely unsupervised. When action = 1 and $e_t^{norm} \geq T_{conf}$: $r_i = \lambda \times \max(0, e_t^{norm})$. When action = 1 and $e_t^{norm} < T_{conf}$: $r_i = \lambda \times e_t^{norm} - 0.5$. When action = 0: $r_i = 0$. Here λ = 0.8.

F. Algorithm Implementations and Hyperparameters

Four DRL configurations are implemented with Stable-Baselines3 (v1.8.0) on a Google Colab T4 GPU. All algorithms share the hyperparameters listed in Table IV. (1) DQN: feedforward MlpPolicy with experience replay and target network updated every 1,000 steps. (2) QR-DQN: distributional extension using quantile regression over N = 200 quantiles. (3) PPO: on-policy MlpPolicy with GAE (λ = 0.95). (4) Recurrent PPO: MlpLstmPolicy with 1 LSTM layer of 128 hidden units, maintaining temporal context through hidden-state propagation between episodes.

Table IV. Hyperparameter configurations for all four DRL algorithms.

Hyperparameter	DQN	QR-DQN	PPO	Rec. PPO
Learning rate (α)	1×10^{-4}	1×10^{-4}	1×10^{-4}	1×10^{-4}
Discount (γ)	0.99	0.99	0.99	0.99
Entropy coeff.	—	—	0.02	0.02
Replay buffer	150,000	150,000	—	—
Batch size	64	64	64	64
n_steps	—	—	128	128
LSTM units	—	—	—	128
Episode length	2,000	2,000	2,000	2,000
Total timesteps	500,000	500,000	500,000	500,000

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

A. Overall Performance Comparison

Table I presents test-set performance of all four DRL configurations on Edge-IIoTset. FPR ↓ denotes lower is better. Recurrent PPO achieves the highest F1-score (0.9342) and AUC-ROC (0.9573), with the lowest FPR (0.0206), identifying 70,065 true positive anomalies while generating only 651 false alarms out of 31,669 normal test windows. Standard DQN provides a well-balanced baseline with the highest precision (0.9846) and competitive AUC-ROC (0.9324), but incurs 11,038 false negatives due to limited temporal modeling without explicit memory. QR-DQN improves recall from 0.8608 to 0.8947 over standard DQN, achieving F1 = 0.9290. Non-recurrent PPO achieves near-perfect recall (0.9436) but at the cost of 14,955 false positives (FPR = 0.4721), making it operationally impractical.

Table I. Overall performance on Edge-IIoTset test set. FPR ↓ = lower is better.

Metric	DQN	QR-DQN	PPO	Rec. PPO
Precision	0.9846	0.9660	0.8334	0.9908
Recall	0.8608	0.8947	0.9436	0.8837
F1-Score	0.9185	0.9290	0.8851	0.9342
FPR ↓	0.0338	0.0789	0.4721	0.0206
Accuracy	0.8909	0.9023	0.8249	0.9111
AUC-ROC	0.9324	0.9193	0.8886	0.9573

Table VII presents the raw confusion matrix counts underlying Table I. The total test set consists of 31,669 normal windows and 79,290 anomalous windows. Recurrent PPO achieves the best balance: 70,065 TP and only 651 FP, demonstrating that its LSTM memory effectively suppresses spurious alerts while maintaining strong anomaly coverage. Standard DQN achieves the highest TN count (30,598) reflecting excellent specificity, but its 11,038 FN reveals systematic blind spots on temporally complex attack patterns. PPO's extreme imbalance (FP = 14,955 versus TN = 16,714) confirms that without recurrence, the on-policy objective over-penalizes missed detections at the cost of precision. QR-DQN strikes the best off-policy balance, with only 2,497 FP while recovering 2,690 additional TP compared to standard DQN.

Table VII. Confusion matrix counts on Edge-IIoTset test set (total: 31,669 normal, 79,290 anomalous windows).

Model	TP	TN	FP	FN
DQN	68,252	30,598	1,071	11,038
QR-DQN	70,942	29,172	2,497	8,348
PPO	74,820	16,714	14,955	4,470
Rec. PPO	70,065	31,018	651	9,225

B. DQN and QR-DQN Analysis

Standard DQN demonstrated stable off-policy convergence, correctly classifying 30,598 normal instances (TN) and 68,252 anomalous instances (TP). Its precision of 0.9846 confirms that when DQN flags an anomaly, it is correct 98.46% of the time. However, 11,038 false negatives indicate that DQN struggles to capture multi-packet attack signatures without temporal memory. QR-DQN improved upon DQN by correctly identifying 70,942 true positives versus 68,252, reducing false negatives by 2,690 (a 24.38% reduction). By modeling the full quantile distribution over N = 200 quantiles, QR-DQN provides more calibrated uncertainty estimates under the noisy semi-supervised reward signal.

C. PPO and Recurrent PPO Analysis

Non-recurrent PPO achieved recall of 0.9436 with 74,820 true positives, but 14,955 false positives (FPR = 0.4721) indicate that nearly half of all normal windows were incorrectly flagged. Without LSTM, PPO evaluates each window independently and cannot exploit contextual continuity across consecutive observations. Recurrent PPO resolved this by integrating an LSTM layer (128 hidden units), reducing false positives by 95.65% relative to non-recurrent PPO (651 vs. 14,955) while maintaining recall of 0.8837. The LSTM accumulates contextual evidence across consecutive sliding windows before committing to an anomaly decision.

D. Per-Attack-Type Performance

Table II presents per-attack-type F1-scores (R-PPO = Recurrent PPO). Recurrent PPO leads all categories. For volumetric attacks (DDoS_UDP and DDoS_ICMP), which together represent 84.85% of anomalous windows, all models perform well. For rare attacks, gaps widen substantially: on Ransomware (1.18%), Recurrent PPO achieves F1 = 0.8671 versus 0.7701 for DQN (Δ = 0.0970). On MITM (0.43%), Recurrent PPO (0.8334) outperforms PPO (0.6668) by Δ = 0.1666 and DQN (0.6989) by Δ = 0.1345, demonstrating the value of temporal memory for detecting multi-stage, low-volume attacks.

Table II. F1-Score by attack type on test set. R-PPO = Recurrent PPO.

Attack Type	DQN	QR-DQN	PPO	R-PPO
DDoS_UDP (43.24%)	0.9185	0.9305	0.8849	0.9492
DDoS_ICMP (41.61%)	0.9119	0.9220	0.8732	0.9450

Uploading (13.54%)	0.8722	0.8851	0.8412	0.9201
Ransomware (1.18%)	0.7701	0.7956	0.7501	0.8671
MITM (0.43%)	0.6989	0.7302	0.6668	0.8334

E. Ablation Studies: ConvAE Threshold

Table III presents AUC-ROC across four ConvAE threshold configurations (spanning both columns). Removing intrinsic rewards entirely (row 1) degrades all models substantially: DQN AUC-ROC falls from 0.9324 to 0.7954 (−11.70%), QR-DQN from 0.9193 to 0.8123 (−13.17%), PPO from 0.8886 to 0.7901 (−12.47%), and Recurrent PPO from 0.9573 to 0.8312 (−6.46%). The Upper Fence row (T = 0.0902) is the best configuration across all models, outperforming Q_3-only (T = 0.0459) by an average of 8.14% AUC-ROC, because Q_3 flags moderate-error normal windows as anomalous, introducing noisy reward signals. The Conservative threshold (T = 0.1345) misses anomalies in the 0.0902–0.1345 MSE range, underperforming the Upper Fence by an average of 1.43%.

Table III. AUC-ROC under different ConvAE threshold configurations. Row 3 = best.

Threshold Configuration	DQN	QR-DQN	PPO	Rec. PPO
No Intrinsic Reward	0.7954	0.8123	0.7901	0.8312
Q_3 only (T = 0.0459)	0.8510	0.8656	0.8443	0.9034
Upper Fence (T = 0.0902)	0.9324	0.9193	0.8886	0.9573
Conservative (T = 0.1345)	0.8687	0.8721	0.8454	0.9256

F. Ablation: Replay Buffer and LSTM

Replay Buffer: For DQN and QR-DQN, the 150,000-transition buffer achieved the best precision-recall balance. Reducing to 100,000 lowered experience diversity, causing recall to drop to 0.8361 (DQN). Increasing to 200,000 caused precision to collapse to 0.8421 (DQN) due to over-representation of rare anomaly patterns, skewing the value function toward aggressive detection. LSTM Ablation: Removing LSTM from Recurrent PPO while retaining all other settings reduced F1 by 10.16 percentage points (0.9342 →0.8326) and increased false positives by 23.03× (651 →14,993), confirming that temporal memory is the dominant driver of Recurrent PPO's advantage.

G. Training Convergence and Computational Cost

All agents were trained for 500,000 timesteps on a Google Colab T4 GPU. DQN converged earliest at approximately 180,000 steps (36.00% of total budget), followed by QR-DQN at 200,000 steps (40.00%). On-policy algorithms required more steps: PPO at approximately 310,000 steps (62.00%) and Recurrent PPO at 360,000 steps (72.00%), reflecting higher variance of on-policy gradient estimates. Wall-clock training times were: DQN 42 min, QR-DQN 58 min, PPO 31 min, and Recurrent PPO 67 min. For inference, all agents process windows in under 1 ms on CPU, making real-time deployment feasible.

H. Comparison with Prior Work

Our framework's DQN configuration achieves AUC-ROC of 0.9324 on Edge-IIoTset, an improvement of 0.0612 (+7.02%) over the DPLAN baseline [4] (AUC-ROC 0.8712). Ferrag et al. [5] reported supervised CNN F1 = 0.9812 on Edge-IIoTset under full-label conditions; our semi-supervised Recurrent PPO achieves F1 = 0.9342 using only 5% of anomaly labels, recovering 95.21% of fully supervised performance with 95.00% less label annotation effort. Lopez-Martin et al. [9] reported DQN-based intrusion detection F1 = 0.8940; our QR-DQN achieves F1 = 0.9290 (+3.91%) on a more challenging 14-class benchmark.

I. Limitations

This study acknowledges the following limitations. First, the framework produces binary (normal/anomaly) decisions without classifying the specific attack type, limiting forensic utility. Second, evaluation is performed on a single dataset; generalization to other IoT environments requires further validation. Third, the ConvAE pretraining phase requires a corpus of clean normal-traffic windows, which may be difficult to obtain in heavily compromised network segments. Fourth, Recurrent PPO's training time of 67 minutes and LSTM inference overhead may limit deployment on severely resource-constrained IoT edge devices. Fifth, the 5% labeled anomaly assumption may not reflect all real-world settings.

V. CONCLUSION

This paper presented a systematic, controlled comparison of four DRL algorithms for semi-supervised anomaly detection in IoT-based cyberattacks, using a unified ConvAE intrinsic reward framework on Edge-IIoTset (2,219,201 records, 14 attack types). Key findings are:

(1) Recurrent PPO with LSTM achieved the best overall performance (F1 = 0.9342, AUC-ROC = 0.9573, FPR = 0.0206), demonstrating that temporal memory is critical for detecting short-burst and multi-stage IoT attacks. Its LSTM policy reduced false positives by 95.65% relative to non-recurrent PPO while using only 5% of anomaly labels.

(2) Standard DQN provided a strong, high-precision baseline (Precision = 0.9846, AUC-ROC = 0.9324) suitable for deployments where false alarms are the primary concern. QR-DQN improved recall by 3.36 percentage points through distributional uncertainty modeling.

(3) Non-recurrent PPO, despite near-perfect recall (0.9436), is unsuitable for production deployment due to extreme over-detection (FPR = 0.4721). Recurrence is a necessary component for on-policy methods in sequential IoT traffic settings.

(4) ConvAE intrinsic rewards are essential: removing them degrades AUC-ROC by 6.46%–13.17% across algorithms. The IQR-based Upper Fence threshold (T = 0.0902 MSE) is the optimal operating point, outperforming alternatives by 1.43%–8.14%.

Future work will explore Transformer-based temporal encoders, federated semi-supervised DRL for distributed edge deployments, active learning, multi-class attack classification extensions, and evaluation on BoT-IoT and TON-IoT benchmarks.

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